14.1 Exponential functions

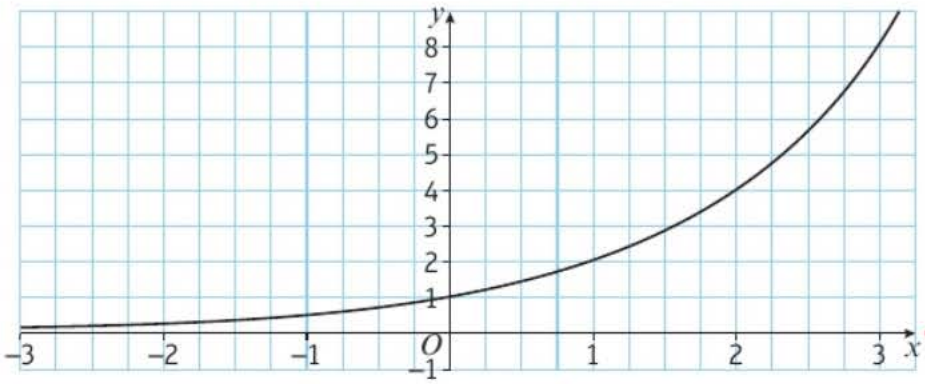
Functions of the form $f(x) = a^x$, where a is a constant, are called **exponential functions**. You should become familiar with these functions and the shapes of their graphs.

For an example, look at a table of values of $y = 2^x$.

x	−3	−2	−1	0	1	2	3
y	$\frac{1}{8}$	$\frac{1}{4}$	$\frac{1}{2}$	1	2	4	8

The value of 2^x tends towards 0 as x decreases, and grows without limit as x increases.

The graph of $y = 2^x$ is a smooth curve that looks like this:



The x-axis is an asymptote to the curve.

Notation In the expression 2^x, x can be called an **index**, a **power** or an **exponent.**

Links Recall that $2^0 = 1$ and that $2^{-3} = \frac{1}{2^3} = \frac{1}{8}$ ← Section 1.4

Example 1

a On the same axes sketch the graphs of $y = 3^x$, $y = 2^x$ and $y = 1.5^x$.

b On another set of axes sketch the graphs of $y = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^x$ and $y = 2^x$.

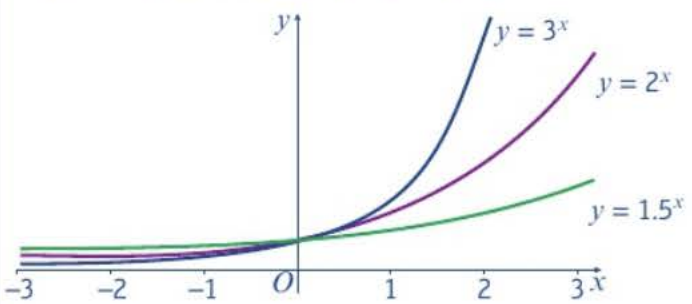
a For all three graphs, $y = 1$ when $x = 0$.

$a^0 = 1$

When $x > 0$, $3^x > 2^x > 1.5^x$.

When $x < 0$, $3^x < 2^x < 1.5^x$.

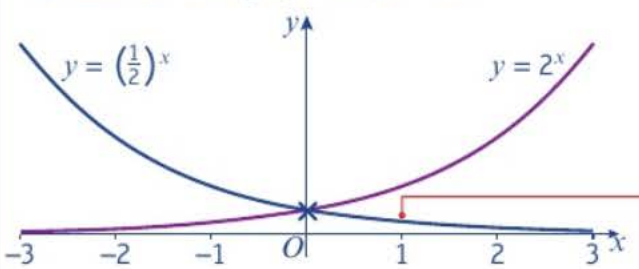
Work out the relative positions of the three graphs.



Whenever $a > 1$, $f(x) = a^x$ is an increasing function. In this case, the value of a^x grows without limit as x **increases**, and tends towards 0 as x **decreases**.

b The graph of $y = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^x$ is a reflection in the y-axis of the graph of $y = 2^x$.

Since $\frac{1}{2} = 2^{-1}$, $y = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^x$ is the same as $y = (2^{-1})^x = 2^{-x}$.

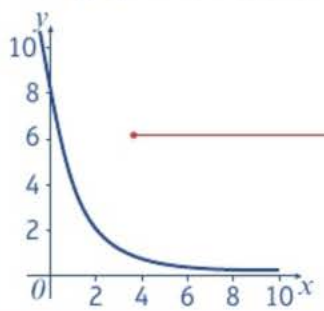


Whenever $0 < a < 1$, $f(x) = a^x$ is a decreasing function. In this case, the value of a^x tends towards 0 as x **increases**, and grows without limit as x **decreases**.

Example 2

Sketch the graph of $y = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^{x-3}$. Give the coordinates of the point where the graph crosses the y-axis.

If $f(x) = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^x$ then $y = f(x - 3)$.
The graph is a translation of the graph $y = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^x$ by the vector $\begin{pmatrix}3\\0\end{pmatrix}$.
The graph crosses the y-axis when $x = 0$.
$y = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^{0-3}$
$y = 8$
The graph crosses the y-axis at $(0, 8)$.



Problem-solving

If you have to sketch the graph of an unfamiliar function, try writing it as a transformation of a familiar function. ← Section 4.5

You can also consider this graph as a stretch of the graph $y = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^x$

$$y = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^{x-3}$$
$$= \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^x \times \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^{-3}$$
$$= \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^x \times 8$$
$$= 8\left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^x = 8f(x)$$

So the graph of $y = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^{x-3}$ is a vertical stretch of the graph of $y = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^x$ with scale factor 8.

Exercise 14A

1 **a** Draw an accurate graph of $y = (1.7)^x$, for $-4 \leqslant x \leqslant 4$.
b Use your graph to solve the equation $(1.7)^x = 4$.

2 **a** Draw an accurate graph of $y = (0.6)^x$, for $-4 \leqslant x \leqslant 4$.
b Use your graph to solve the equation $(0.6)^x = 2$.

3 Sketch the graph of $y = 1^x$.

(P) **4** For each of these statements, decide whether it is true or false, justifying your answer or offering a counter-example.
a The graph of $y = a^x$ passes through $(0, 1)$ for all positive real numbers a.
b The function $f(x) = a^x$ is always an increasing function for $a > 0$.
c The graph of $y = a^x$, where a is a positive real number, never crosses the x-axis.

5 The function $f(x)$ is defined as $f(x) = 3^x$, $x \in \mathbb{R}$. On the same axes, sketch the graphs of:
a $y = f(x)$ **b** $y = 2f(x)$ **c** $y = f(x) - 4$ **d** $y = f\left(\frac{1}{2}x\right)$
Write down the coordinates of the point where each graph crosses the y-axis, and give the equations of any asymptotes.

(P) **6** The graph of $y = ka^x$ passes through the points $(1, 6)$ and $(4, 48)$. Find the values of the constants k and a.

Problem-solving

Substitute the coordinates into $y = ka^x$ to create two simultaneous equations. Use division to eliminate one of the two unknowns.

(P) **7** The graph of $y = pq^x$ passes through the points $(-3, 150)$ and $(2, 0.048)$.

a By drawing a sketch or otherwise, explain why $0 < q < 1$.

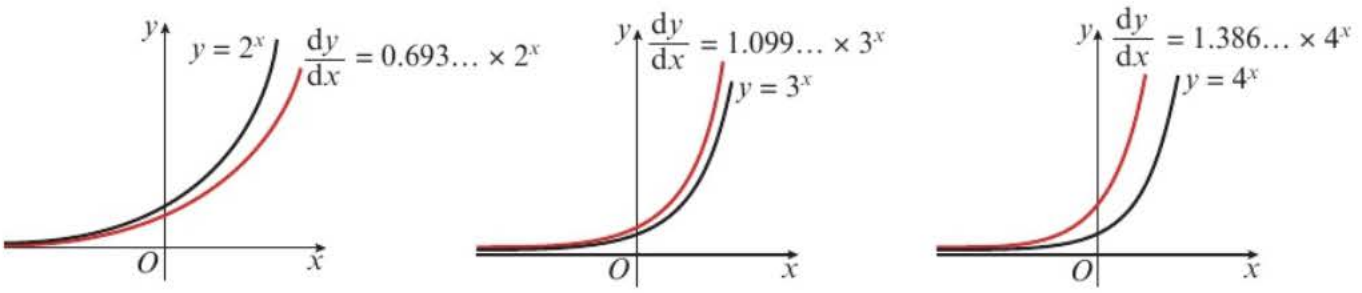
b Find the values of the constants p and q.

Challenge

Sketch the graph of $y = 2^{x-2} + 5$. Give the coordinates of the point where the graph crosses the y-axis.

14.2 $y = e^x$

Exponential functions of the form $f(x) = a^x$ have a special mathematical property. The graphs of their gradient functions are a similar shape to the graphs of the functions themselves.



In each case $f'(x) = kf(x)$, where k is a constant. As the value of a increases, so does the value of k.

Something unique happens between $a = 2$ and $a = 3$. There is going to be a value of a where the gradient function is exactly the same as the original function. This occurs when a is approximately equal to 2.71828. The exact value is represented by the letter e. Like π, e is both an important mathematical constant and an irrational number.

Function	Gradient function
$f(x) = 1^x$	$f'(x) = 0 \times 1^x$
$f(x) = 2^x$	$f'(x) = 0.693... \times 2^x$
$f(x) = 3^x$	$f'(x) = 1.099... \times 3^x$
$f(x) = 4^x$	$f'(x) = 1.386... \times 4^x$

Online Explore the relationship between exponential functions and their derivatives using GeoGebra.

- **For all real values of x:**
  - **If $f(x) = e^x$ then $f'(x) = e^x$**
  - **If $y = e^x$ then $\dfrac{dy}{dx} = e^x$**

A similar result holds for functions such as e^{5x}, e^{-x} and $e^{\frac{1}{2}x}$.

- **For all real values of x and for any constant k:**
  - **If $f(x) = e^{kx}$ then $f'(x) = ke^{kx}$**
  - **If $y = e^{kx}$ then $\dfrac{dy}{dx} = ke^{kx}$**

E/P 5 On Earth, the atmospheric pressure, p, in bars can be modelled approximately by the formula $p = e^{-0.13h}$ where h is the height above sea level in kilometres.

a Use this model to estimate the pressure at the top of Mount Rainier, which has an altitude of 4.394 km. **(1 mark)**

b Demonstrate that $\frac{dp}{dh} = kp$ where k is a constant to be found. **(2 marks)**

c Interpret the significance of the sign of k in part **b**. **(1 mark)**

d This model predicts that the atmospheric pressure will change by $s\%$ for every kilometre gained in height. Calculate the value of s. **(3 marks)**

E/P 6 Nigel has bought a tractor for £20 000. He wants to model the depreciation of the value of his tractor, £T, in t years. His friend suggests two models:

Model 1: $T = 20\,000e^{-0.24t}$

Model 2: $T = 19\,000e^{-0.255t} + 1000$

a Use both models to predict the value of the tractor after one year. Compare your results. **(2 marks)**

b Use both models to predict the value of the tractor after ten years. Compare your results. **(2 marks)**

c Sketch a graph of T against t for both models. **(2 marks)**

d Interpret the meaning of the 1000 in model 2, and suggest why this might make model 2 more realistic. **(1 mark)**

14.4 Logarithms

The inverses of exponential functions are called **logarithms**. A relationship which is expressed using an exponent can also be written in terms of logarithms.

- **$\log_a n = x$ is equivalent to $a^x = n$ $\quad (a \neq 1)$**

Notation a is called the base of the logarithm.

Example 6

Write each statement as a logarithm.

a $3^2 = 9$ **b** $2^7 = 128$ **c** $64^{\frac{1}{2}} = 8$

a $3^2 = 9$, so $\log_3 9 = 2$

b $2^7 = 128$, so $\log_2 128 = 7$

c $64^{\frac{1}{2}} = 8$, so $\log_{64} 8 = \frac{1}{2}$

In words, you would say 'the logarithm of 9 to the base 3 is 2'.

Logarithms can take fractional or negative values.

Example 7

Rewrite each statement using a power.

a $\log_3 81 = 4$ **b** $\log_2\left(\frac{1}{8}\right) = -3$

a $\log_3 81 = 4$, so $3^4 = 81$

b $\log_2\left(\frac{1}{8}\right) = -3$, so $2^{-3} = \frac{1}{8}$

Example 8

Without using a calculator, find the value of:

a $\log_3 81$ **b** $\log_4 0.25$ **c** $\log_{0.5} 4$ **d** $\log_a (a^5)$

a $\log_3 81 = 4$ — Because $3^4 = 81$.

b $\log_4 0.25 = -1$ — Because $4^{-1} = \frac{1}{4} = 0.25$.

c $\log_{0.5} 4 = -2$ — Because $0.5^{-2} = \left(\frac{1}{2}\right)^{-2} = 2^2 = 4$.

d $\log_a (a^5) = 5$ — Because $a^5 = a^5$.

You can use your calculator to find logarithms of any base. Some calculators have a specific $\log_{\square}\square$ key for this function. Most calculators also have separate buttons for logarithms to the base 10 (usually written as log) and logarithms to the base e (usually written as ln).

Notation Logarithms to the base e are typically called **natural logarithms**. This is why the calculator key is labelled ln.

Online Use the logarithm buttons on your calculator.

Example 9

Use your calculator to find the following logarithms to 3 decimal places.

a $\log_3 40$ **b** $\log_e 8$ **c** $\log_{10} 75$

a 3.358 — For part **a** use $\log_{\square}\square$.

b 2.079 — For part **b** you can use either ln or $\log_{\square}\square$.

c 1.875 — For part **c** you can use either log or $\log_{\square}\square$.

Exercise 14D

1 Rewrite using a logarithm.

a $4^4 = 256$ **b** $3^{-2} = \frac{1}{9}$ **c** $10^6 = 1\,000\,000$

d $11^1 = 11$ **e** $(0.2)^3 = 0.008$

2 Rewrite using a power.

a $\log_2 16 = 4$ **b** $\log_5 25 = 2$ **c** $\log_9 3 = \frac{1}{2}$

d $\log_5 0.2 = -1$ **e** $\log_{10} 100\,000 = 5$

3 Without using a calculator, find the value of

a $\log_2 8$ **b** $\log_5 25$ **c** $\log_{10} 10\,000\,000$ **d** $\log_{12} 12$

e $\log_3 729$ **f** $\log_{10}\sqrt{10}$ **g** $\log_4 (0.25)$ **h** $\log_{0.25} 16$

i $\log_a (a^{10})$ **j** $\log_{\frac{2}{3}}\left(\frac{9}{4}\right)$

4 Without using a calculator, find the value of x for which

a $\log_5 x = 4$ **b** $\log_x 81 = 2$ **c** $\log_7 x = 1$

d $\log_2 (x - 1) = 3$ **e** $\log_3 (4x + 1) = 4$ **f** $\log_x (2x) = 2$

5 Use your calculator to evaluate these logarithms to three decimal places.

a $\log_9 230$ **b** $\log_5 33$ **c** $\log_{10} 1020$ **d** $\log_e 3$

(P) **6 a** Without using a calculator, justify why the value of $\log_2 50$ must be between 5 and 6.

b Use a calculator to find the exact value of $\log_2 50$ to 4 significant figures.

Hint Use corresponding statements involving powers of 2.

7 a Find the values of:

i $\log_2 2$ **ii** $\log_3 3$ **iii** $\log_{17} 17$

b Explain why $\log_a a$ has the same value for all positive values of a ($a \neq 1$).

8 a Find the values of:

i $\log_2 1$ **ii** $\log_3 1$ **iii** $\log_{17} 1$

b Explain why $\log_a 1$ has the same value for all positive values of a ($a \neq 1$).

14.5 Laws of logarithms

Expressions involving more than one logarithm can often be rearranged or simplified. For instance:

$\log_a x = m$ and $\log_a y = n$ — Take two logarithms with the same base

$x = a^m$ and $y = a^n$ — Rewrite these expressions using powers

$xy = a^m \times a^n = a^{m+n}$ — Multiply these powers

$\log_a xy = m + n = \log_a x + \log_a y$ — Rewrite your result using logarithms

This result is one of the **laws of logarithms**.

You can use similar methods to prove two further laws.

- **The laws of logarithms:**
  - $\log_a x + \log_a y = \log_a xy$ **(the multiplication law)**
  - $\log_a x - \log_a y = \log_a \left(\frac{x}{y}\right)$ **(the division law)**
  - $\log_a (x^k) = k \log_a x$ **(the power law)**

Watch out You need to learn these three laws of logarithms, and the special cases below.

- **You should also learn to recognise the following special cases:**
  - $\log_a \left(\frac{1}{x}\right) = \log_a (x^{-1}) = -\log_a x$ **(the power law when $k = -1$)**
  - $\log_a a = 1$ **($a > 0$, $a \neq 1$)**
  - $\log_a 1 = 0$ **($a > 0$, $a \neq 1$)**